

Orchestral Exploration: Mahler

Stage/Year: 5/ Year 10	Term 4/Week: 7
Lesson Duration:	1 hour
Learning Goal Students will explore orchestration, timbre, and structural elements of a movement of a Mahler symphony by creating modern DAW-based interpretations of score excerpts that have been put imported to the DAW as MIDI. This activity will heighten awareness of melodic, harmonic, and rhythmic content, preparing students for attentive listening during the live Sydney Symphony Orchestra performance.	
Students learn about: • Orchestral timbres, textures, and instrumentation in Mahler's score. • How pitch, rhythm, and dynamics are represented in written notation. • How DAW tools (synths, effects, sound design) can reinterpret classical music while respecting the original score.	
Students learn to: • Import short score excerpts into a DAW and assign timbres creatively. • Experiment with synth textures, effects, and layering while using only the original notes. • Analyse the structure of each excerpt and make reflective compositional decisions. • Discuss how timbral choices affect the perception of the music and prepare for live listening.	

Curriculum Link & Cross-Curriculum Priorities

NSW Music Years 7–10 Syllabus (Stage 5):

Concept of Music – Tone Colour, Texture, Structure, Dynamics.

Cross-Curriculum Priorities:

- Critical and Creative Thinking: Analysing and reinterpreting orchestral excerpts in a DAW.
- Digital Literacy: Using DAWs to manipulate musical material.

Related Syllabus Outcomes (Stage 5)

- 5.5 – Evaluates and explains the impact of performance and orchestration on audience experience.
- 5.7 – Extends aural discrimination skills, identifying instrumentation, timbre, and texture.
- 5.8 – Applies music concepts to composition and performance.

Success Criteria:

By the end of the lesson students can:

- Import a short Mahler score excerpt into a DAW and correctly sequence the notes.
- Select and manipulate timbres, effects, and textures to create a personal interpretation.
- Identify structural and orchestral elements in their excerpt and describe them verbally.
- Reflect on how these choices might influence their live listening experience at the excursion

Lesson 1 Teaching and Learning Sequence

Time	Activity	Focus Area (Perform/Compose/Listen)
5 min	Introduction & Goal – Overview of Mahler Symphony 5, M4, discussing orchestration highlights, and how this DAW exercise prepares for the concert.	Listening / Teacher talk
10 min	Teacher Led Analysis – Examine 8–16 bar excerpts in the DAW; identify instruments, motifs, dynamics, and texture. Provide examples of how to manipulate the score in the DAW	Listening / Responding
15 min	Composition Task – In pairs or individually, students reimagine the excerpt in the DAW, using only the original notes but exploring timbre, synth sounds, and effects.	Composing / Performing

Time	Activity	Focus Area (Perform/Compose/Listen)
10 min	Peer Sharing – Students play their DAW interpretations to a small group, discuss timbral choices, and how it changes the music’s character.	Listening / Responding
5 min	Class Reflection – Teacher-led discussion: How did timbre and effects change perception? How does this prepare us to listen attentively to the live performance?	Listening / Responding
5 min	Exit Ticket – Write one observation about orchestration or timbre in symphonic movement they will notice in the concert.	Responding / Listening